

Chicago Tribune



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FRIDAY, OCTOBER 3, 2025

BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Grants to Metra and CTA could have catch

Awards may require cooperation with federal immigration enforcement

By Talia Soglin
Chicago Tribune

The CTA and Metra have been awarded federal counterterrorism grants that could require them to cooperate with federal immigration enforcement, although it's unclear if the agencies plan to take the money.

The grants, administered by the Federal Emergency Management Agency, are used by mass transit agencies around the country to fund security and counterterrorism measures.

But transit agencies that accept the funds this year could be agreeing to cooperate with federal immigration enforcement operations down the road. The decision that the CTA and Metra must make comes as Chicago finds itself in the crosshairs of President Donald Trump's immigration crackdown.

FEMA is part of the Department of Homeland Security, which earlier this year updated its grant terms and conditions to include provisions requiring cooperation with immigration enforcement.

Illinois and a coalition of other states sued over those grant terms and won a permanent injunction in their favor last week.

Plaintiffs in the lawsuit won't be subject to the grant's immigration conditions while the injunction is in place, according to FEMA documents. However, the terms would apply immediately should the injunction be stayed or vacated, the documents say.

In previous years, the CTA has received funds from the Transit Security Grant Program for projects including video monitoring of train stations and "collaboration" with Chicago police, including canine units, according to the agency's most recent budget.

The CTA was allocated \$15.7 million in transit security money this year, spokesperson Manny Gonzales confirmed. The region's commuter rail system, Metra, received a grant of about \$688,000, said agency spokesperson Michael Gillis.

Gillis said Metra was still deciding whether or not to take the grant, which would be used by the Metra Police Department to test out the use of drones to respond to threats and emergencies, he said.

The CTA would not say whether it planned to accept the money or what it would be used for.

"CTA can confirm that it has received an Award Letter for the Department of Homeland Security's Transit Security Grant in the

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A U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement agent chases a protester into a residential yard near the ICE holding facility in Broadview on Sept. 26.
E. JASON WAMBSGANS/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Broadview in epicenter of immigration battles

Residents scared as ICE facility a front line in Trump's blitz

By Andrew Carter
Chicago Tribune

From the open window in her dining room, Dana Caruso watched the bedlam unfold late last week off of 25th Avenue in Broadview. The road to an Immigration and Customs Enforcement facility is just across the street and the sight of unmarked

ICE vans and protesters had already become commonplace, when early last Friday she heard what sounded like artillery fire and saw people running.

The smell of gas wafted through her window, an odor she finds difficult to describe but even harder to forget. She watched while men in what appeared to be military fatigues, dressed for battle, gave chase through the street and into her backyard. She could still see it all days later — and smell it, and hear it — while she sat at the window

and recounted a morning that left her family traumatized.

Caruso relived the kind of scene that prompted Katrina Thompson, the mayor of Broadview, to publicly rebuke ICE and the Department of Homeland Security. Her village, a town of less than 8,000 people 13 miles west of Chicago, has become the unwitting epicenter of President Donald Trump's crusade against illegal immigration, a campaign that has some locals hiding in fear and others loathing the smell of tear gas in the morning.

Since the Department of Homeland Security launched the so-called Operation Midway Blitz in early September, Fridays have been marked by violent clashes between ICE agents and demonstrators during planned protests at the detention center. After federal authorities deployed tear gas on Sept. 26 for the second straight week, DHS asked the Department of Defense to deploy 100 military troops to the Chicago area to help "end the

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Mother, children released from ICE custody

Family detained in Millennium Park; father still being held

By Laura Rodríguez Presa and Madeline Buckley
Chicago Tribune

A mother and her two children who were detained in Millennium Park on Sunday by immigration agents were released from custody Wednesday, bringing a moment of relief and renewed hope for the Chicago-area family caught in the

crosshairs of aggressive federal immigration enforcement.

The move came after a federal judge ordered that the family, including Noemi Chavez and their 8 year-old daughter and 3-year-old son, are protected from deportation or removal from Illinois while the government responds to a habeas corpus petition filed by attorneys with the National Immigrant Justice Center. However, the children's father, Jaime Ramirez, remains in a Texas immigration facility

after being transferred from Illinois earlier this week.

"We are so grateful for all the people who have stepped in to help," said Miguel Angel Mejia, a family member. "We're praying for a miracle so that my Uncle Jaime is reunited with his family in Chicago. They should be together."

On Monday, attorneys for the Ramirez-Chavez family filed a petition in U.S. District Court in Chicago seeking their release or a bond hearing. The legal filing challenges the U.S. Department

of Homeland Security's current interpretation of mandatory detention, arguing that the family poses no danger to the community and is not a flight risk.

According to the petition, a new DHS policy — the legality of which is under ongoing legal scrutiny — allows for the detention of anyone who entered the U.S. without inspection, without providing opportunity for release on bond. Several federal courts have since rejected that interpretation.

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CHRIS SWEDA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Moving on to Milwaukee

Cubs relief pitchers Andrew Kittredge, from left, and Daniel Palencia and catcher Carson Kelly celebrate after beating the Padres 3-1 in Game 3 of the NL wild-card series at Wrigley Field on Thursday. The Cubs advance to the National League Division Series against the Brewers. **Chicago Sports**

MICHIGAN CITY

Building boom aims to draw Chicagoans to visit and stay

Officials try to change image from industrial town to tourist attraction

By Robert McCoppin
Chicago Tribune

Tour boat captain Vic Tieri started Harbor Country Adventures on the lakefront in southwest Michigan, but later moved it down the coast and expanded in Michigan City, Indiana.

"I felt like Michigan City was in a position to grow," Tieri said. "Now I made the smart bet, because I look at all the construction cranes and new apartments and condos. Everywhere you look, there's new

stuff going up."

If the Midwest is flyover country for coastal elites, then Indiana traditionally has been drive-through country for Chicagoans holding their noses on their way to vacation in "Pure" Michigan. Now, Michigan City officials are trying to change their town's image from that of an industrial town to a tourist destination, and a new home for Chicago commuters.

The city of 33,000, a mixture of blue-collar workplace and lakefront playground, has benefited from several major developments in recent years. It is the home of a planned \$300 million luxury hotel

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TODAY'S WEATHER High 89 Low 67

Complete Chicagoland forecast on Page 12

\$4.00 city and suburbs and elsewhere
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